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Values for the future.



Dear readers

On 1 April 1955 my father listed his company in the local commercial register. Switzerland was on the rise. The economy was flourishing and technological advances were opening up new opportunities. Hard work, a focus on precision, and entrepreneurial courage were the values that shaped the early days of the company. My father knew that quality was the key to success. This principle remains deeply embedded in our corporate culture today.

What began as a small mechanical workshop is now a globally respected manufacturer of precision moulds. In 1977, without speaking a word of English, my father accepted the company's first order for a PET preform mould, which came from a company in the US. His confidence in his own abilities paid off. Today, about one in ten PET bottles is made from a preform that was created using a mould from Otto Hofstetter AG.

In 1997, my father handed the company over to me. It was a great moment, given the deep respect I had for his life's work and the awareness of the responsibility that I was taking on. Almost thirty years later, I am proud of how our company has developed. It is clear to me that our success would not be possible without our employees and partners, many of whom have been with us for decades. Day after day, they put their knowledge, experience and passion to their work. And, to be sure, our relationships with our customers are equally important. They have continuously put their trust in us and grown with us. I am deeply grateful for that.

Now the third generation of our family is already working in the company, gaining valuable experience. One day, they will take the reins one day and develop the company. And I am certain that they will preserve our core values and continue to write the history of Otto Hofstetter AG with fresh ideas.

Today, the world is changing rapidly. Political and economic developments bring uncertainty, as old structures dissolve and new alliances emerge. But some things remain constant: the trust of our customers, the strength of our team and the enthusiasm of the young people who have joined us. This issue of "inform" presents some examples of this spirit. It's about the customers who have been with us for decades, the committed employees who drive our success, and the talented young talents who are helping to shape the future with their energy and their innovations.

I wish you enjoyable, informative reading and look forward to many more years of rewarding collaboration with you.

Yours, Otto Hofstetter

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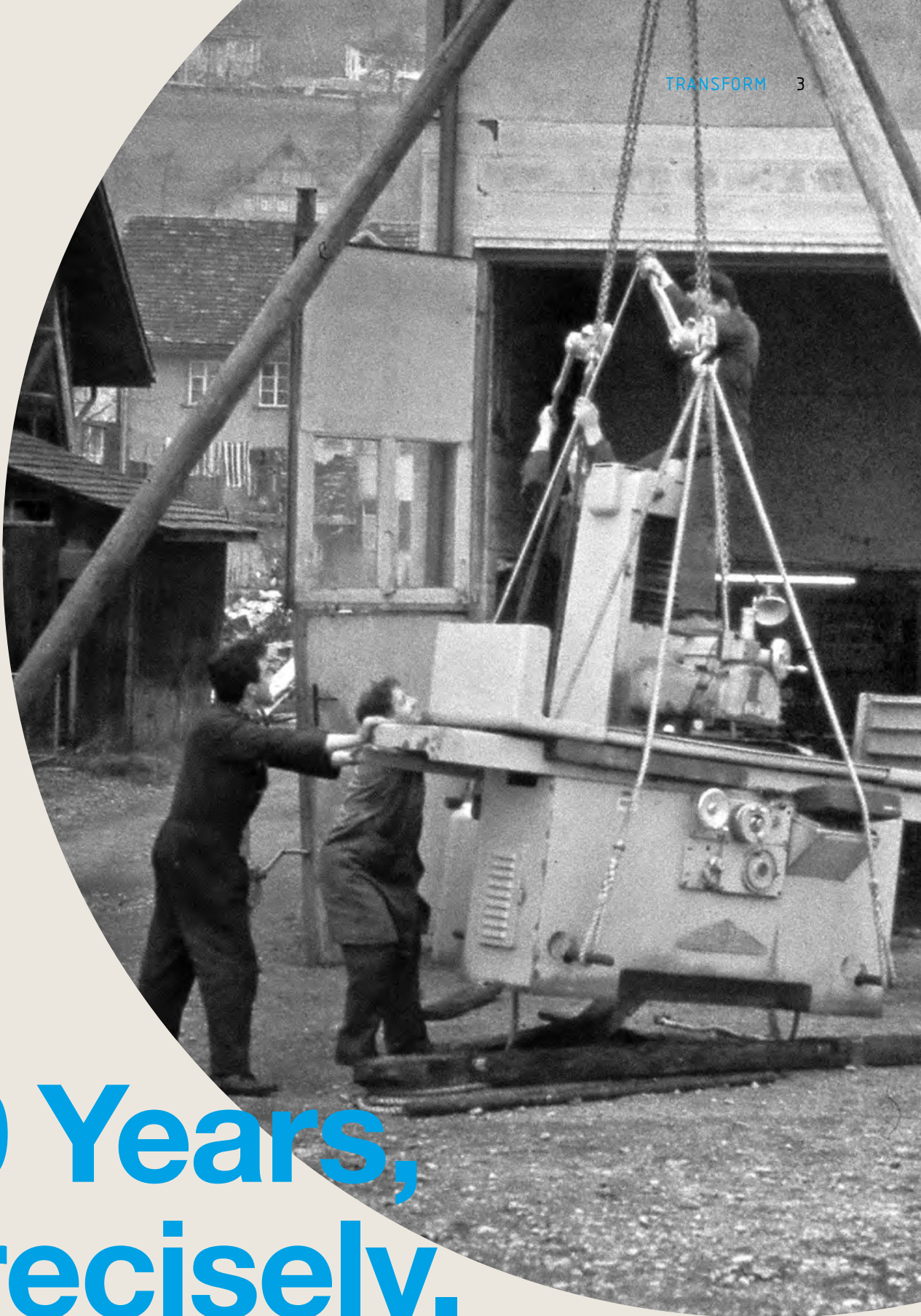
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70 Years, precisely.

From its **start-up in a small-town garage** to its well-earned position as a global leader in the manufacture of high-precision injection moulds, **Otto Hofstetter AG's journey** goes back **seven decades**. It's a story of bold innovation and unwavering determination. This Swiss family business continues to shape the industry today while remaining true to its **roots and its core values**. And the journey continues.

The Early Years: From Garage Business to Global Player

1955

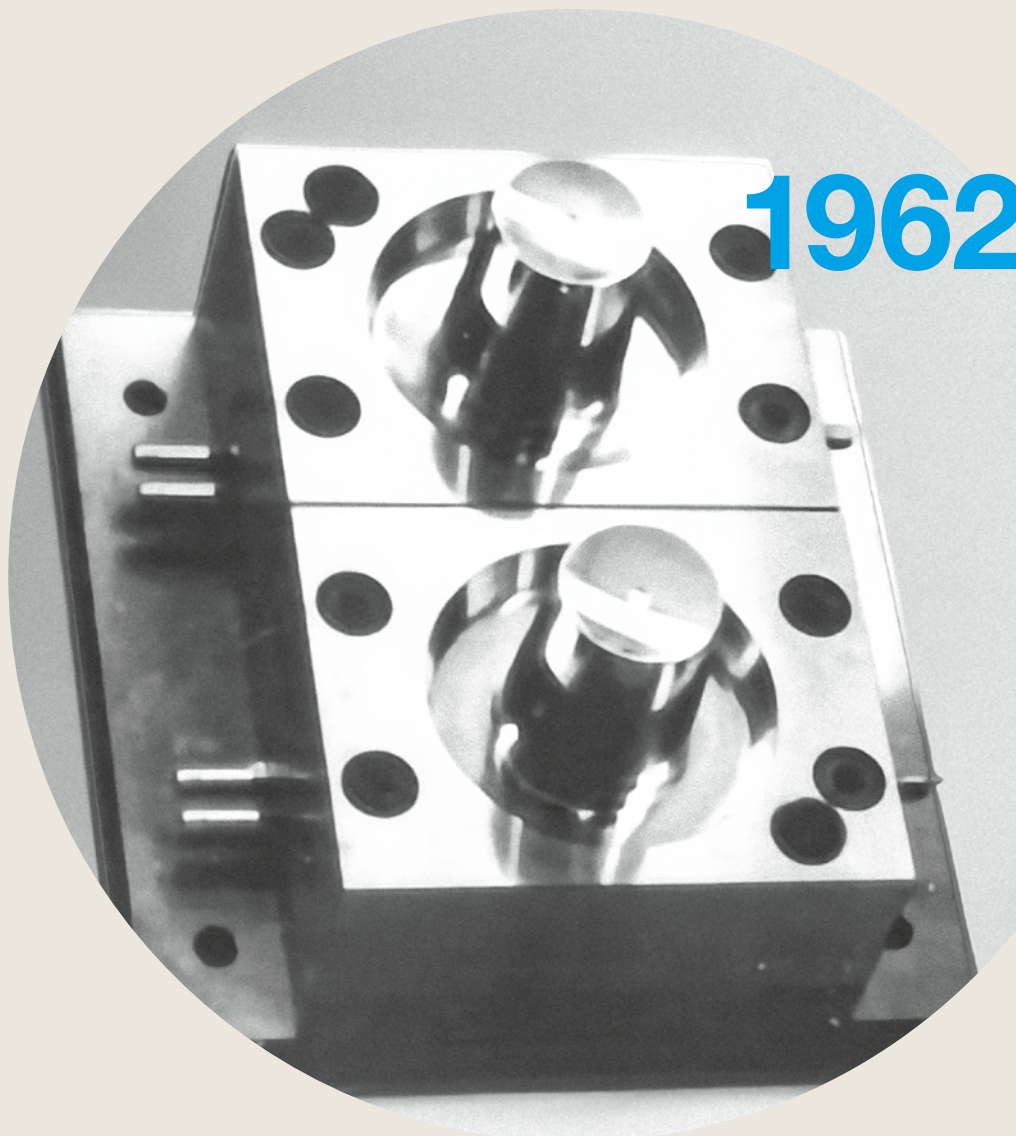
Otto Hofstetter Sr. establishes a machine shop focusing on traditional tasks such as drilling, turning and milling, but he craves innovation and new challenges. His commitment to quality is evident from day one, setting the foundation for the decades of excellence to follow.

1962

The company takes a bold step into mould manufacturing for plastic, producing its first specialised injection moulds for thin-walled packaging. This strategic move marks the beginning of Otto Hofstetter AG's expertise in food and consumer goods packaging. The first two-cavity cup mould is produced with a wall thickness of 3 mm – a far cry from today's 0.3 mm precision.

1963

Growing steadily, Otto Hofstetter AG moves to larger premises in Uznach, Switzerland, which remains the company's headquarters. The new facility provides the space needed for expanded manufacturing and continuous R&D.

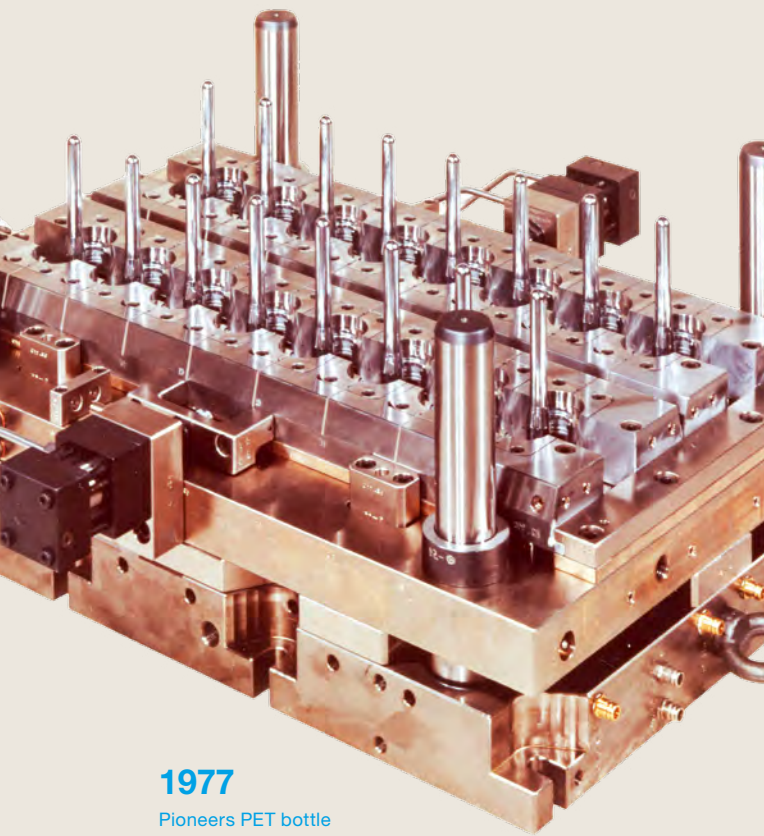


Entry into the injection mould manufacturing business.

1963



Move to new building and current headquarters in Uznach.



1977

Pioneers PET bottle preforms with a 16-cavity mould.

PET Pioneer: The Transformative Years

1977

A pivotal moment comes when Continental Can approaches Otto Hofstetter Sr. about replacing PVC with PET for its bottles. Despite having no experience with PET preform moulds, he embraces the challenge. The company produces its first injection mould for PET preforms, with 16 cavities, marking a bold entry into the beverage packaging industry.

1985

Otto Hofstetter Jr. joins the company as head of production, bringing fresh perspectives and energy. This same year, the company introduces its TiN coating for cores and neck splits, demonstrating an early commitment to surface protection technology. Under his leadership, the company takes on the challenge of building moulds that are "twice as big and twice as fast" to meet customer demands.

1997

A new chapter begins as Otto Hofstetter Sr. hands over leadership to his son, ensuring the company remains family-owned and positioned for future growth. The transition preserves the company's values while embracing modern management approaches.



1985

Otto Hofstetter Jr. joins the company as head of production.



Otto Hofstetter Sr. hands over management to his son.

Global Expansion: Meeting Worldwide Demand

2001

Recognising the vast potential of the Indian market, Otto Hofstetter AG opens a branch in Bangalore. This facility produces moulds exclusively for the Indian market, addressing local needs while maintaining the company's renowned quality standards.

2012

The company's global footprint expands further with the opening of a branch in Shenzhen, China. This strategic move enhances service capabilities in the rapidly growing Asian market and demonstrates the company's commitment to serving customers worldwide.

2014

Otto Hofstetter Jr.'s entrepreneurial vision and leadership are recognised when he receives the prestigious EY Entrepreneur of the Year award in Switzerland. This acknowledgment honours the company's outstanding performance in a competitive global market.



Opening of the branch
in Luxembourg.

2001



Branch opened
in Bangalore, India.



2012

Branch opened
in Shenzhen, China

Diversification and Innovation: The Modern Era

2016

Building on decades of expertise, the company launches Otto Systems, a sister company offering complete turnkey production lines for PET preforms. Otto Systems allows the Hofstetter group to serve customers as a one-stop shop for complete systems rather than just moulds.

2017

The opening of the Luxembourg branch strengthens the engineering and technical support capabilities for the company. This addition reinforces the company's European presence and enhances its ability to provide rapid-response service to customers.



2019

Expansion into medical applications as a dedicated area of expertise.

2019

Always ready for new challenges, Otto Hofstetter AG establishes its MED business unit, manufacturing high-precision moulds for medical applications. This diversification leverages the company's expertise in precision manufacturing for a demanding new market segment.

The Third Generation: Preparing for the Future

2023

The company's commitment to nurturing talent is recognised when Otto Hofstetter AG is certified as a TOP apprenticeship company. This acknowledgment highlights the firm's dedication to the Swiss two-track apprenticeship system – learning on the job and in the classroom. Today, approximately a-third of its workforce is made up of former apprentices.



2024

The new Otto Systems TechCenter opens in Uznach.

2024

Opening of the new TechCenter for Otto Systems, adjacent to Otto Hofstetter AG's headquarters in Uznach, another milestone. In the same year, new facilities are opened at the Otto Hofstetter India branch, further strengthening operations in the Indian market.

2025 and beyond

The third generation of the Hofstetter family joins the business as Otto Hofstetter Jr.'s three children come on board. Thus, the company assures that it will continue to focus on its customers' success in future. The transition is characterised by both continuity and innovation, as Otto Hofstetter Jr. guides rather than leads the next generation, helping them create their own structures while maintaining the company's core values.

Set to lead.

In just two years, **Sarooj Water** has become a **leading water provider in Oman**. In an interview, **Fahad Mohammed Riaz** explains how well-considered technology decisions and a clear **focus on quality and efficiency** have enabled them to offer a high-quality product at a competitive price. The combination of **precise manufacturing**, optimised processes and clear market positioning has made the company the market leader in the 250 ml bottle segment in a short time.

What motivated you to establish Sarooj Water in Oman?

Founding Sarooj Water was the result of a thorough market analysis. We found that the Omani market was heavily dominated by imported water, especially from the United Arab Emirates, Bahrain and Saudi Arabia. Although there were some local providers, none could compete with the imported brands in terms of production capacity or pricing.

In addition, the prices for imported water in Oman were very high. Consumers sometimes paid between two and two-and-a-half US dollars per carton. This not only seemed like an economic challenge to us, but also a clear opportunity. Why should Omanis continue to depend on imports when, as our analysis showed, it would be possible for local production to meet the highest quality standards?

Our motivation was therefore twofold: firstly, we wanted to establish a strong Omani brand that could compete with imported products, and secondly, we wanted to offer consumers a better price by producing efficiently and with optimised cost structures.

How has your company developed since it was founded?

We started very small. The first production line had a capacity of 25,000 bottles per hour – rather modest for the water industry. It began as a pilot project, a marketing test to see how our products would be received.

We soon saw that our strategy worked. Within a very short time, we established ourselves as a leading provider of small bottle sizes. Today, we produce 118,000 bottles per hour, and, despite this enormous capacity, we are sold out. Demand far exceeds what we can supply, so we have already ordered an additional line that will add another 155,000 bottles per hour.

This rapid success would not have been possible without the efforts of our strong team. Our parent company, Mohammed Riaz & Partner, has been active in Oman since 1997 and has a broad network of business contacts. We were already one of the largest importers of food, especially poultry, and therefore had good relationships with the major retailers. These connections helped us to quickly get our water into the supermarkets.

How would you describe your company's philosophy?

We take a holistic approach. Our goal is not just to sell water, but to create maximum added value for the consumer. This includes a focus on giving consumers good value for money

as well as the continuous improvement of our processes.

When we started out in the water business, one role model for us was the US company Niagara Water. It's a family-run company that has grown over the years by focusing on efficient production, innovative packaging solutions and close partnerships with suppliers. A meeting with the Peykoff family, Niagara Water's owner, cemented my approach: focus on one product, one lightweight bottle and mass production.

To achieve our goals, we rigorously pursue the optimal use of all resources. We use the latest technologies to minimise water consumption in production and continuously develop our

bottles to reduce the amount of plastic they require.

**"TODAY, WE PRODUCE
118,000 BOTTLES PER HOUR –
AND WE ARE STILL SOLD OUT."**

Fahad Mohammed Riaz, CEO of Sarooj Water

How does Sarooj Water differentiate itself from other water brands in Oman?

There are around 43 water brands in Oman, produced by more than 30 companies, so the competition is intense. We have deliberately focused on the 250 ml bottle segment and established ourselves as the market leader here.

The trend is clearly towards smaller packaging sizes as they are more practical and hygienic. Our strategy is to remain number one in this segment while expanding our production capacity to open up new market segments.

Which markets do you currently serve and which new markets are you interested in expanding into?

Oman is our main market – we sell 80% to 90% of our water here. However, we already export to the United Arab Emirates, especially Dubai, Abu Dhabi and Al Ain. Our products are available in most major retail chains.

There is a huge demand from neighbouring countries. We are constantly receiving inquiries from the UAE and Kuwait, but our current production capacity is not yet sufficient to fully serve these markets.

The new production line will significantly increase our exports. Over the long term, we also see potential in Saudi Arabia, which is one of the largest markets in the region.

What is Oman Vision 2040 and how does it affect your business strategy?

Oman Vision 2040 is a government program that aims to pro-

mote economic diversification and sustainability in our country. Among other things, it envisages reducing dependence on imports and strengthening local production generally.

We are actively contributing to this vision by locating as much of our value chain as possible in Oman. We source packaging materials, boxes and labels from local manufacturers and create jobs for Omani citizens.

Another important point is the reduction of plastic. Our goal is to use up to 45% less plastic per bottle in the next few years, which is in line with the sustainability goals of Vision 2040.

What changes in consumer behaviour are you observing?

The most important trend is the increasing demand for small packaging units. Previously, 500 ml and 1.5 l bottles dominated the market, but today consumers prefer smaller bottles because they are more convenient and hygienic.

"WHY SHOULD OMANIS RELY ON IMPORTS WHEN LOCAL PRODUCTION CAN MEET THE HIGHEST QUALITY STANDARDS?"

Fahad Mohammed Riaz, CEO of Sarooj Water

There is also a growing interest in mineralised and alkaline water, but these segments are still relatively small in Oman. In the future, I could even see a further downsizing to 200 ml bottles as consumers become more conscious of not wasting water.

How do you navigate competition in the FMCG sector?

In addition to quality and price, reliability as a supplier is a key factor. A competitor may have a lower price, but if they are unable to deliver large quantities on time, they will not be successful in the long term.

We continuously invest in our production capacity to meet the growing demand. At the same time, we work with the best suppliers to ensure the highest quality.

Success in our business is also about taste. Our water comes from an underground source that is virtually sodium-free and has a refreshing, balanced taste. Consumers won't buy even very cheap water if it doesn't taste good.



Aiming at a capacity of 250,000 bottles per hour, Sarooj Water relies on state-of-the-art technology and a high degree of automation.

What trends do you expect for the future of the water industry?

The reduction of plastic will play a central role. We are already working on lighter bottles and testing alternative materials. The trend is clearly towards environmentally friendly bottles and smaller formats.

How important is automation in your production processes? Without automation, we would not be able to produce efficiently. Our goal is to reach a capacity of 250,000 bottles per hour in the next few years, and this will only be possible with state-of-the-art technology.

If you visit our production line, you will see how few employees are needed to produce 118,000 bottles per hour. Only a handful of people are needed to monitor the entire process, while our competitors need significantly more staff.

How do you ensure consistent water quality?

We use real-time monitoring systems and have our own laboratory that regularly analyses samples. We are also ISO- and HACCP-certified. Quality control is absolutely essential in the water business. If the quality isn't right, you are producing

118,000 bottles per hour that consumers could potentially have problems with. We cannot take that risk, which is why we test every batch twice before it leaves production.

We also have a team that monitors the market and randomly tests products at our customers' stores. We also train distributors on how to store the water properly – not next to chemicals, for example, and not in the sun, as temperatures here can reach up to 50° C.

What factors influenced your decision to work with Otto Hofstetter AG for your first mould in 2022?

When I did my due diligence on Otto Hofstetter AG, I was most impressed by the precision they could offer. The accurate design, optimal cycle times and smart system integration were key factors in my decision. In the water bottling business, precision is everything. You need the right preform with the right cycle time and the right integrated cooling system. A competent toolmaker can make a good mould, but you need the right cooling system and injection technology to have a complete solution.

Partnering with a Swiss company like Otto Hofstetter AG has



been crucial to our success. The reliability and durability of their moulds allows us to operate 24/7 with minimal downtime.

How did the pilot phase go when you started preform production?

The pilot phase was challenging, as it was my introduction to the water-bottling business. I wasn't familiar with preforms and had to learn how they behave in the blow-moulding process. Starting small was crucial to gain know-how along the entire production chain.

I conducted small-scale tests, collecting preforms and testing them on our filling machines to ensure they functioned properly under real production conditions. It was a cautious approach but necessary to ensure we got everything right from the very beginning.

How did working with Otto Hofstetter AG influence your preform designs?

Thanks to Otto Hofstetter AG, we were able to reduce the weight of our preforms from 7.5 to 6.3 g – a saving of 11%. This was only possible thanks to the precision engineering and expertise they brought to the project. A key factor in our success was Otto Hofstetter AG's ability to build a 128-cavity mould for our special preform design. This was a significant technical achievement, as previously this type of lightweight preform was only produced on smaller moulds with fewer cavities.

The Otto Hofstetter AG mould runs in our top-entry injection moulding system and achieves excellent efficiency rates – our system runs at 98% efficiency. The material savings quickly compensated for the additional investment in high-quality tooling and in-house preform production. For our 250 ml bottle, we chose a bottle with the 29/25 closure that is common in the region. With the special neck geometry, it was possible to make the bottle 8% lighter, at 6.85 g. The material savings quickly paid for themselves and made the additional costs of producing preforms and closures in-house worthwhile.

What aspects of working with Otto Hofstetter AG do you particularly appreciate?

I especially value the relationship we have built. Working with Otto Hofstetter AG feels like being part of a family. We can openly discuss any issues, and their team is always available. I can call their representative any time, regardless of whether it is a weekend or outside working hours.

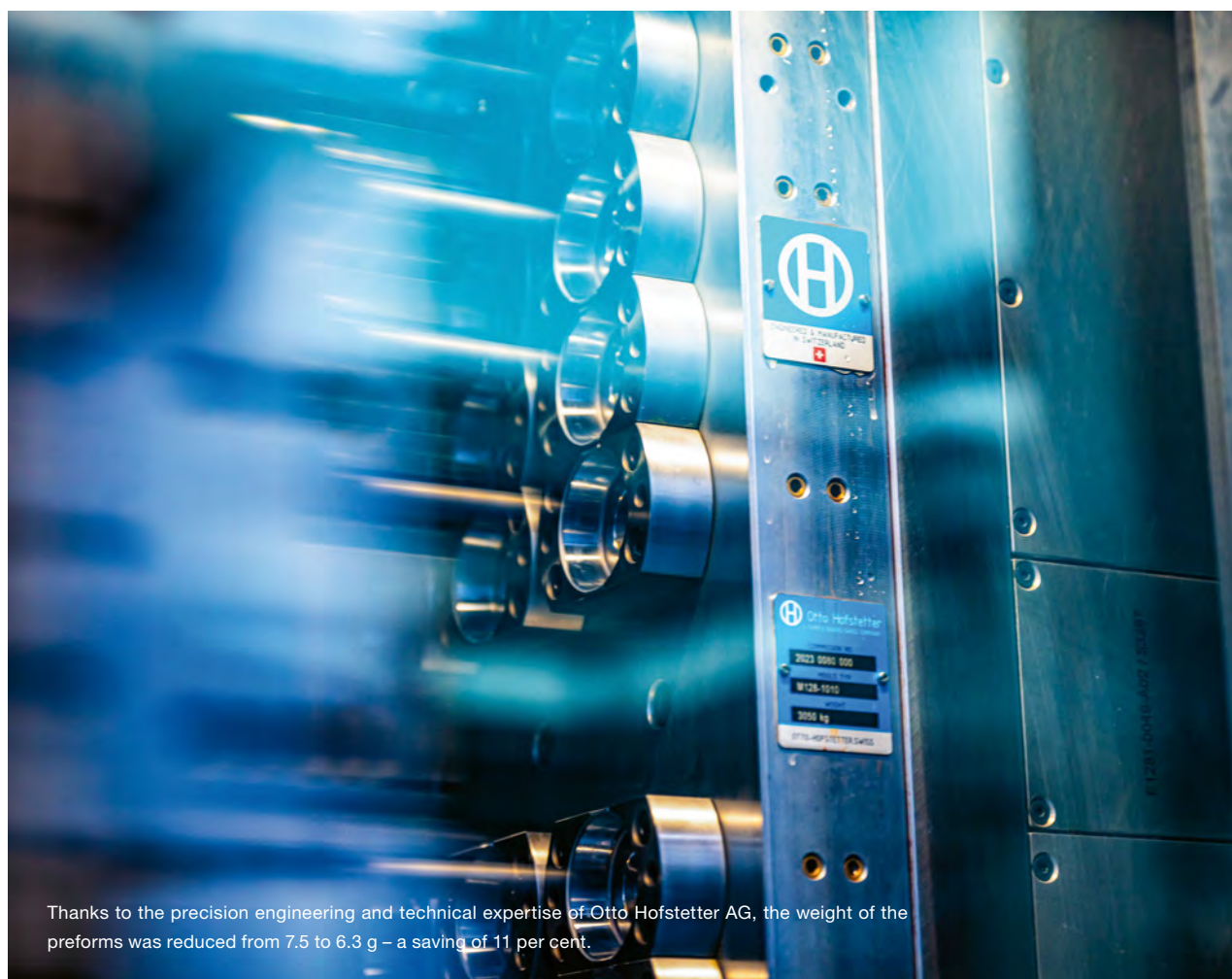
Their approach is not just about sales; it's about providing the right solution. They have been excellent consultants, taking care

**"I ESPECIALLY VALUE THE
RELATIONSHIP WE HAVE BUILT.
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HOFSTETTER AG FEELS LIKE
BEING PART OF A FAMILY."**

Fahad Mohammed Riaz, CEO of Sarooj Water



The 128-cavity mould from Otto Hofstetter AG runs in a top-entry system at Sarooj Water and achieves an efficiency of 98 per cent.



Thanks to the precision engineering and technical expertise of Otto Hofstetter AG, the weight of the preforms was reduced from 7.5 to 6.3 g – a saving of 11 per cent.

of our needs and helping us achieve our goals. The other crucial aspect is the precision of their designs. Not everyone can produce high-quality preforms with reliably consistent cycle times. Their technical support has also been exceptional. If we have a problem, one call is all it takes to get help. Even small spare parts are delivered by air freight, if needed, and they really understand the customer's pain when a production line is forced to stop.

How do you plan to develop Sarooj Water over the next five years?

Our goal is to become the market leader in all packaging sizes. We aim to expand our range to include 500 ml and 1.5 l bottles and grow our export markets. The next step in our growth strategy is to add another production line with a capacity of 155,000 bottles per hour, which I mentioned earlier. This will enable us to better serve the growing demand in Oman and help us expand our presence in neighbouring countries.

What is your long-term vision for Sarooj Water?

We aspire to establish Sarooj as the leading water brand in Oman and across the GCC. Our focus will continue to be on maximum efficiency, superior quality and sustainable packaging solutions.

We plan to grow our business five-fold over the next five years, not only by increasing our production capacity but also by entering different market segments. Sustainability will continue to be a key focus, with ongoing efforts to reduce the amount of plastic in our bottles.

The journey has only just begun, and, with the continued support of partners like Otto Hofstetter AG, we are confident that we can achieve our ambitious goals.



Sarooj Water
www.saroojwater.com, info@saroojwater.com

Founded: 2021
 Specialist for: Leading supplier of premium-quality drinking water
 Industries: FMCG, drinking water

Maladdah OM, 111, Muscat, Oman

Job training with a vision.

Switzerland's MEM industry – machinery, electrical engineering and metals – is recognised worldwide for quality and innovation. One key to its success is the steady supply of highly skilled labour thanks to the close cooperation between vocational schools and industry. Industrial Vocational Training Switzerland (“libs” in German) works with around 180 member companies, providing optimised training programmes to over 1,000 apprentices. Otto Hofstetter AG is a member of the libs programme.



Training tomorrow's high-skilled workers

libs aims to provide young people with the best basic vocational training. The foundation of the programme consists of personal responsibility, lifelong learning and active engagement in shaping one's own future. libs is an association that appeals to companies of all sizes, from big global corporations like ABB to small- and medium-sized companies like Otto Hofstetter AG. "Our strength lies in our close cooperation with industry," explains Marcel Allemann, head of the libs centre in Rapperswil, near Otto Hofstetter AG. "This allows us to continually adapt the training content to current market requirements."

State-of-the-art learning environment

The organisation's four training centres are equipped with the latest technology. This is where the foundations are laid for

careers in the technical and commercial fields are laid. The training model combines solid basic and supplementary training at libs with specialised training at the partner companies. "We combine the best of both worlds", says Allemann. "With us, the trainees benefit from modern infrastructure and experienced vocational instructors, while the companies further qualify them in specific specialist areas."

Flexibility for individual paths

libs offers training models that adapt to the needs of both trainees and companies. In the classic model, the trainees first complete the basic training at libs before moving on to the partner companies. This system has advantages for both sides. "The trainees gain valuable experience and the companies gain highly qualified young talent", says Allemann. With a share of



During their second year of their apprenticeship as polymer technologists, Roman Bühler and Lorenzo Gregorio are receiving their basic vocational training at libs under instructor Marcel Allemann.

around eleven percent of all apprenticeship contracts within Swiss MEM member companies, libs plays a central role in the training of young specialists.

A reliable partner for the future

Otto Hofstetter AG has been working closely with libs for two years. A few weeks ago, another plastics technologist apprentice was recruited for the start of the apprenticeship in 2025. "The basic training at libs is an important pillar for us", says Charles Akers, plastics technologist supervisor at Otto Hofstetter AG. "It also gives future apprentices the tools they need to assert themselves later in a highly specialised industry." Two current examples of this collaboration are Roman Bühler and Lorenzo Gregorio.

The two young plastics technologists, both in the second year of their apprenticeships, are currently completing their basic training at libs and will continue their specialised training at Otto Hofstetter AG in summer 2025. They will spend time in every department so that they get to know the up- and downstream processes and their interrelationships. "The injection moulding process is complex and requires a holistic understanding in order to be able to advise customers correctly", emphasizes Akers. "Only those who understand the entire process chain can later develop optimal solutions."

Practical relevance as the key to success

The close connection between theory and practice is special

feature of the training at libs. The trainees work on real projects and production orders that optimally prepare them for their professional future. In the organisation's modern training centres, they are familiarised with the latest machines and technologies. "The practical application of what they have learned motivates the trainees and shows them why their knowledge is important", explains libs' Marcel Allemann. This not only enhances the quality of the training, but also the young people's identification with their profession.

More than just vocational training

libs not only imparts technical skills, but also promotes entrepreneurial thinking. Since 2021, the trainees have been taking part in the "Entrepreneur House" course. Already in the first year of their apprenticeship, they acquire the ability to structure and validate business ideas. In the optional second year of training, they learn how to bring a product to market and start up a company. "Our goal is not only to provide young people with technical training, but also to inspire them to think and act entrepreneurially", explains Allemann.

Investing in the future

For Otto Hofstetter AG, the collaboration with libs is more than just a question of personnel. "We are investing in our future", says Stefan Zatti, Division Manager Sales and Marketing. "We can only maintain our leading position in mouldmaking with well-trained specialists." The libs training organisation continually adapts its programmes. New technologies and changing market requirements are directly incorporated into the curricula. At the same time, the organisation is investing in training more vocational instructors and in the modernisation of its infrastructure.

Switzerland's dual education system, as exemplified by libs, is a model of success. It combines theory and practice and strengthens Switzerland as a place to work for the long term. Partner companies such as Otto Hofstetter AG benefit from this, as do the skilled workers who complete their training here.

Fit for the challenges of tomorrow.

The MEM industry is facing major challenges: digitisation, technological innovations and global competition. Meeting these challenges requires highly qualified employees. libs has created the conditions to actively shape this change. With practice-oriented training, modern infrastructure and a strong anchoring in industry, the association ensures that Switzerland can continue to build on a strong base of skilled workers in the future.

Steel going strong.

Otto Hofstetter AG uses specially developed **high-performance steels** in its injection moulds. Cooperating closely with **thyssenkrupp Materials Schweiz AG**, an "all-stainless" concept is being developed that will **enhance the durability of our precision moulds** while reducing the environmental impact of their manufacture.



New projects will further improve the already good environmental performance of the steel used for the moulds of Otto Hofstetter AG.

The exceptional reliability and durability of Otto Hofstetter AG's moulds are well known in the industry. Mould availability of over 98 percent and up to 20 million cycles before the first maintenance are benchmarks that speak for themselves. The low wear of moving parts in our moulds and the wide range of maintenance and overhaul options guarantee exceptional longevity. What's more, conversions and adjustments can be easily implemented, as the main components of the moulds are designed for extreme durability. Clearly, this kind of mould performance can only be achieved through the careful selection of the materials used to make them.

Tailor-made materials

Otto Hofstetter AG's moulds are used around the world and they have to function under a wide range of climatic conditions – from regions with high humidity to arid deserts. In all cases, they must withstand the stresses caused by plastics that are processed at temperatures as high as 300° C. Thus, the steel we use must be of the highest quality. The basic structure of our moulds is made of a distortion-free and corrosion-resistant plastic mould steel called THYROPLAST-2294, which also has the advantage of being particularly easy to machine.

The actual moulding parts of the mould are made of THYROPLAST-2083 ESU. This steel is produced using the electro-slag remelting process, which significantly improves its purity. After soft machining, it is hardened to 50-52 HRC, which makes the steel optimally corrosion-resistant and easy to polish.

Quality through partnership

The collaboration with thyssenkrupp Materials Schweiz AG is based on mutual trust and the joint pursuit of optimal solutions. Through our detailed process understanding, the material specifications can be continuously improved. Otto Hofstetter AG shares its comprehensive process know-how with thyssenkrupp Materials Schweiz AG, which enables a precise analysis of the relevant parameters and the ongoing optimisation of the special steels that we need.

Around 80 percent of the steels used in Otto Hofstetter AG moulds comes from Germany, and 15 percent from Italy. The longstanding connection to the steelworks and the close co-operation we enjoy with their management guarantee the consistently high quality of our moulds.

Focus on sustainability

The topics of sustainability are increasingly important in the development and production of injection moulds. The THYROPLAST-2294 steel that is currently used already consists of 61 percent scrap, which significantly reduces its ecological footprint. The steel's CO₂ footprint mainly depends on how it is produced and the additives required. In essence, a higher scrap content reduces the environmental footprint.

The materials in Otto Hofstetter AG's moulds are of such high quality that even after their service life has come to an end, our moulds can be collected, processed and recycled back into production. The valuable alloy components, such as chromium, are an important resource in corrosion-resistant mould steels.

Otto Hofstetter AG has launched several projects to further improve mould performance and reduce the environmental impact of its steels, which is already internationally competi-



Steel cuttings and turnings from processing at thyssenkrupp Materials Schweiz are carefully sorted according to type.

tive. We will regularly update progress in this area in future issues of InForm.



Cooperating with metallurgical specialists of thyssenkrupp Materials Schweiz, the steel used in Otto Hofstetter AG's moulds is continuously improved.



Precision wins.

Nick Zingg is completing an **apprenticeship** as a **polymechanic** at Otto Hofstetter AG along with one special sideline: **The 16-year-old is also a competitive athlete in the regional squad of the Eastern Swiss Ski Association.** In this interview, he talks about how he balances work and sport, the parallels he sees between metalworking and slalom skiing, and why good planning is **crucial for success** in both.

You started your apprenticeship at Otto Hofstetter AG on 1 August, 2024. What motivated you to choose an apprenticeship as a polymechanic?

The profession of polymechanics appealed to me because of my keen interest in technical devices and the joy I get from making things. While looking for an apprenticeship, I also applied for joinery and carpentry. Ultimately, I was won over by the Otto Hofstetter AG's training workshop, with four apprentices taken on per year. This set-up allows us to form a really good team and gives us a wonderful opportunity to exchange ideas. The company isn't far from where my family lives. My mother had learned about the company from a steel supplier and, gave me the tip.

How do you manage being a competitive athlete during your apprenticeship?

There isn't actually a formal programme for athletes here, as Otto Hofstetter AG isn't an official training company recognised by Swiss Olympic, the national Olympic committee. In my application, I simply asked whether a sports apprenticeship would be possible. Together with my parents, we discussed how training and absences could be planned. The resulting supplementary contract regulates exactly how to combine sports and work. Every Sunday, my weekly schedule with the training times goes to Stephan Brändli, my instructor at the company.

How is your training as a polymechanic structured?

I spend three days a week at the company and two days at vocational school. One perk is that we can complete the inter-company course work in-house. The instructors, Stephan Brändli and Marcel Thum, have the relevant additional training, so there's no need to travel to St. Gallen. This is a huge advantage for me, as it allows me to plan and conduct the inter-company courses together with my trainers during my free time. In the course, we learn things like how to manufacture stepped shafts. The rest of the working hours are also very practice-oriented.

What special provisions do you have in your apprenticeship contract?

The supplementary contract allows me to work one day a week to pursue my athletic goals. I am excused from work for additional training and competitions. Of the five weeks of vacation in the first year of my apprenticeship, two weeks are reserved for sports. Unlike other apprentices, there is no performance-related wage tied to school grades. If necessary, my apprenticeship could be extended by another year.

In which areas of polymechanics are you already working?

The first year of the apprenticeship focuses on simpler machines. The programme includes turning and drilling, both manual and with automatic feeds. Milling will follow later. Despite the company's state-of-the-art technology, we begin with the basics of craftsmanship – these provide a better understanding of the work when we move to computer-controlled machines.

What do you particularly enjoy about precision work?

The challenge of precise work and the small tolerances give me a good feeling and confidence when everything is just right. Accuracy must be exact in my work, otherwise a part cannot be used. This precision is also important to me in my personal life, especially when packing for skiing. I have to make sure everything is properly prepared. I take particular care of my skis.

What role does digitalisation play in your training?

In the workshop at Otto Hofstetter AG, digitalisation will come later for me, but at vocational school, almost everything is digital. There, we write with a stylus on the PC screen. We only use a paper notebook for mathematics, while subjects like materials and manufacturing technology are taught exclusively on computers. Programming is planned for the third year of my apprenticeship.

What has been your most interesting project in the workshop so far?

I particularly liked making an adhesive roll holder in the basic course. In this project, we were able to apply all the techniques we had learned so far. Finally, the part was layered to achieve a beautiful surface. This kind of practical work makes the training really interesting.

How do you balance the physical demands of work and sport?

At first, standing for long periods in the workshop was quite tiring, but it didn't affect my training. After intensive training, I sometimes feel a bit tired. Stephan Brändli once noticed this and asked me about it. But with enough sleep—about eight hours a night—it's manageable. At some training sessions, a classmate from high school who plays football accompanies me. We support each other, which is helpful both in sports and at school.

How do your colleagues react to your special apprenticeship?

There have never been any problems or jealousy. Of course,

there is some teasing and little jokes, which I enjoy. The acceptance within the apprentice team is very good. At the beginning of my apprenticeship, Mr. Thum and Mr. Brändli told my new colleagues that I was doing a special apprenticeship and that I would be away a lot due to skiing.

To complete such an apprenticeship, you need a certification from Swiss Olympic. What athletic requirements did you have to meet?

Membership in a regional team is a prerequisite. In the Eastern Swiss Ski Association, the overall assessment is made up of one-third each of skiing results, fitness/athleticism, and a ski technique test. In the latter, experts evaluate various tricks, jumps, and ski runs.



Nick Zingg

Since August 2024, he has been participating as an apprenticeship polymechanic at Otto Hofstetter AG, with the status of a competitive sports apprentice. Member of the regional squad of the Eastern Swiss Ski Association. Two-time Eastern Swiss slalom champion and top-10 finisher in the national Combi race.

How did your career in ski racing begin?

I first stood on skis at the age of two or three and joined the youth organization (JO) at the SSC Toggenburg ski club as early as possible. Success came relatively quickly. At the age of 10, I also began mountain biking training with RV Wetzikon. I practiced both sports concurrently for two or three years before shifting my focus to skiing. Winter being my favorite season and the special feeling at the start—standing alone at the top of the slope—was the deciding factor.

Which skiing discipline do you enjoy most?

Slalom is my favorite discipline, although speed skiing is also appealing. Most people my age haven't yet specialised. At a young age, technical training is a top priority in all disciplines, but the older you get, the more you specialise in individual disciplines. In our five-person team, only the oldest skiers have already decided on their chosen discipline.

Who inspires you in sports?

Several athletes serve as my role models. In skiing, I admire Loïc Meillard for his outstanding technique. In cycling, Tadej Pogačar impresses with his incredible performance – when he can still attack on the last climb after 200 kilometers. In cross-country skiing, I admire Johannes Høsflot Klæbo for his dominance in sprints and his tactical skills.

What do you consider your greatest successes so far?

I've won the overall ranking in the OSSV Alpine Cup three times. Last season brought a top-10 finish in the national Combi Race. Last year I became Eastern Swiss Champion, and the year before that I won the Eastern Swiss Slalom Champion twice. I've also qualified for the finals of the GP Migros, the largest youth ski race in Switzerland, five times.

What does a typical week look like for you?

Monday and Tuesday are dedicated to school, with Monday being particularly long, with classes until 4:30. On Tuesdays, I'm exempt from school sports and instead do a two-hour strength training session outdoors or in the weight room. Wednesday is all about work, followed by training with a friend in the evening. On Thursdays, after work, I go to a nearby town for strength training, and on Fridays, I go back to work. I use the weekends mainly for strength and athletic training in the summer, and for ski training and competitions in the winter. In the summer, we went to the Stelvio Glacier four times for four days each, and twice to the Stubai Glacier, where the training conditions were excellent. In the fall, we trained primarily in Saas-Fee, Zermatt, and on the Schilthorn, where we particularly practiced pole skiing and jumps. There's also a speed course there, which

"THE CHALLENGE OF PRECISE WORK AND THE SMALL TOLERANCES GIVE ME A GOOD FEELING AND CONFIDENCE WHEN EVERYTHING IS JUST RIGHT."

Nick Zingg, polymechanic in training



On the slopes as a competitive ski racer or on the job at Otto Hofstetter AG, the aspiring polymechanic Nick Zingg always strives for the highest precision.

was initially challenging with the new, longer skis.

What similarities do you see between your sport and your job?

Discipline, perseverance, and concentration are crucial in both areas. Reflecting on mistakes sport and work have in common – understanding why something went wrong and how to avoid it in the future is important in both worlds.

How do your coaches support you in your sport and training?

My ski coach, who is also a sports trainer, can identify weaknesses in skiing that are related to physical fitness. At work, Stephan Brändli and Marcel Thum provide similarly positive support. All three motivate with valuable advice and recognition when you're committed and do a good job.

How do you recover from the demands of sports and work?

I enjoy watching skiing, cross-country skiing, and cycling events on TV. In the summer, I head to a nearby lake for

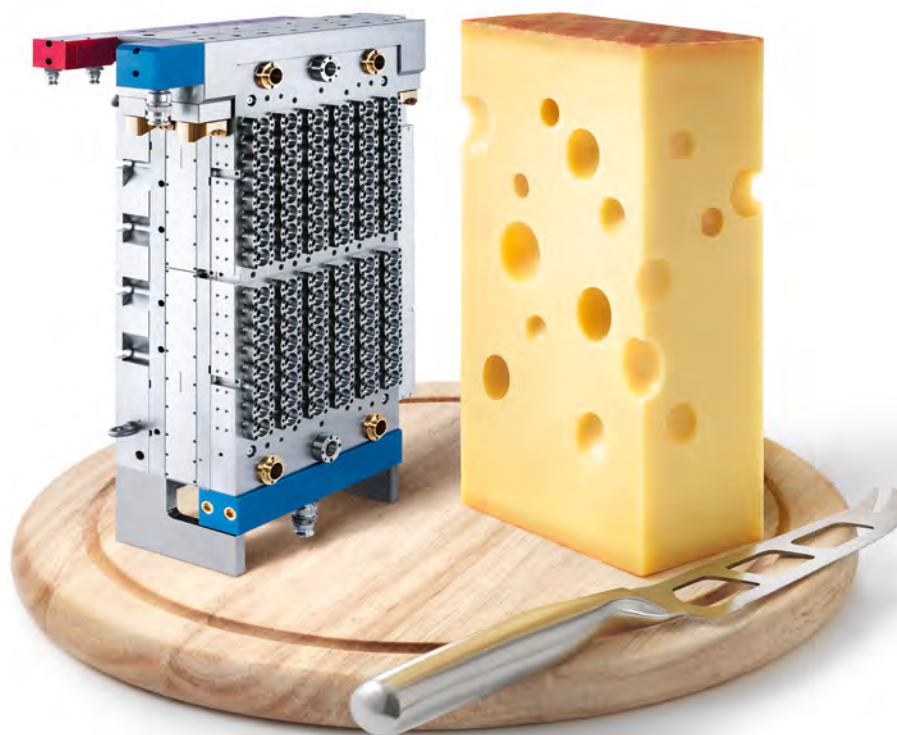
swimming and relaxation. I also spend a lot of time at home on weekends, with my family, my cousins and other relatives.

What advice would you give to other young athletes who are considering a technical apprenticeship?

Advance planning is crucial – at least one week in advance, you should know which dates are booked up. Those around you, especially your instructors, must be informed of absences in a timely manner. It's also important to make a good impression through commitment so that everyone understands that you're fully committed despite frequent absences. Based on my experience so far, I can definitely recommend an apprenticeship as an athlete.

Thank you for the conversation and good luck on your professional and athletic endeavors, Nick.

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